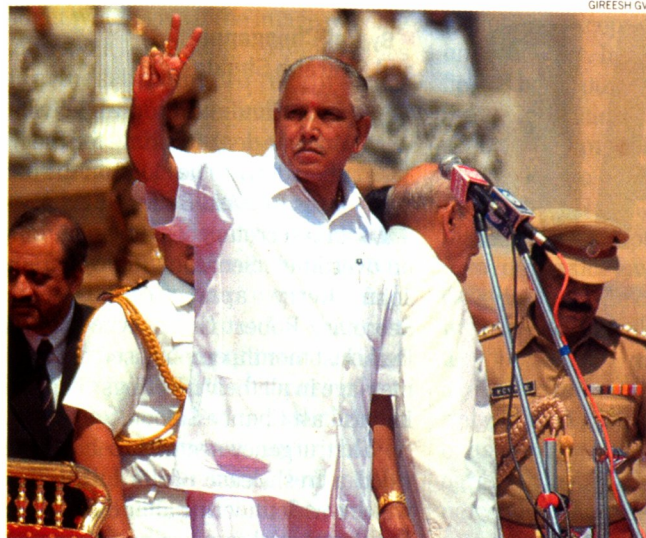




GIREESH GV

IN POLL MODE: Yeddyurappa Mallikharjuna Kharge says the anomalies in the voters' list had to be rectified. He alleges that the voters' list in the BJP-strong Hyderabad-Karnatak region was revised by teachers supporting the saffron party and that the names of thousands of Congress voters were dropped.

BJP's chief minister-hopeful B.S. Yeddyurappa, however, denies this and has his sleeves rolled up for a fight. He says he is ready to move the Supreme Court if the issue of voters' list comes up. "We were ready then and we are ready even now to face the people. The Congress is scared it will be wiped out in the polls," he says. CEC may have ended the debate for now but even he must be aware that Central rule can be extended.

by Stephen David

Congress in a Quandary

BANGALORE Chief Election Commissioner N. Gopalaswami announced here at a meeting on March 4 that the Election Commission (EC) was committed to completing the poll process in the state in time before the end of the President's rule in May.

This comes as a dampener for the hopes of state Congress leaders who, led by Prithviraj Chauhan, had been planning to petition the commission for a postponement of the polls till November.

The party had its list of reasons ready. State Congress unit chief

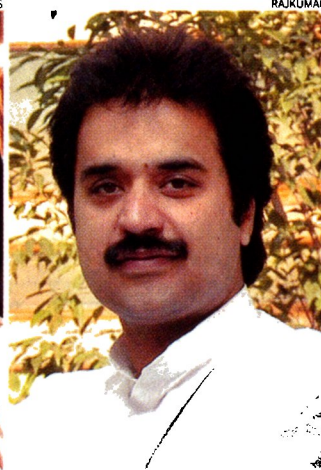
New Turf War in Haryana

CHANDIGARH With the talk of earlier-than-scheduled Lok Sabha elections gaining currency, BSP supremo, Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Mayawati has stepped up her efforts at social engineering in other states. Her latest turf is Haryana where at a rally on March 2, she vowed to install a "non-Jat chief minister" if her party was voted to power.

Though the state Assembly polls are still two years away, Mayawati's new caste mantra is a politically loaded signal towards a possible alliance with Bhajan Lal's Haryana



SIPRA DAS



RAJKUMAR

FRIENDS FOREVER: Mayawati (left); and Bishnoi

Janhit Congress (HJC). Kuldeep Bishnoi, the firebrand president of the party has been cosying up to Mayawati to give shape to his carefully-crafted plans to stitch up a Punjabi-Dalit combination to take on the Congress and Om Prakash

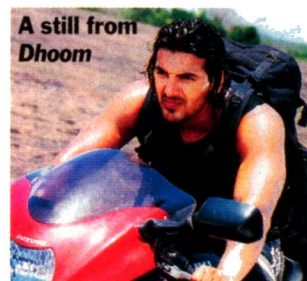
Chautala-led Indian National Lok Dal (INLD).

With growing signs of consolidation of the Punjabi votebank—55 per cent of the total electorate in Haryana—the BSP-HJC combination could be a potent third front in the state.

by Ramesh Vinayak

Doom not Dhoom

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM It was not just the largest bank heist ever in Kerala but also a case of life imitating art. In this case, the architects of the heist in north Kerala drew inspiration from the movie *Dhoom* starring Malluland's most famous export to Bollywood—John Abraham. On New Year's eve, Jaison Thomas and four of his associates in crime checked into a hotel, located below



A still from *Dhoom*

South Malabar Grameen Bank's Malappuram branch. For three days, they stayed in the town, going on recce trips only to return to the hotel in the night to drill a hole through the concrete ceiling of the ground floor room. The task was arduous but success came their way on the fourth day when they managed to drill a hole into the bank's vaultroom. They climbed up and walked out with cash and gold worth Rs 8.25 crore. In an equally unprecedented success in the state police's history, all the five key culprits—including two women—were nabbed in record two months and almost 80 per cent of the money recovered. Thomas, who acknowledged Bollywood's inspirational role, and his accomplices are now cooling their heels in jail.

by M.G. Radhakrishnan